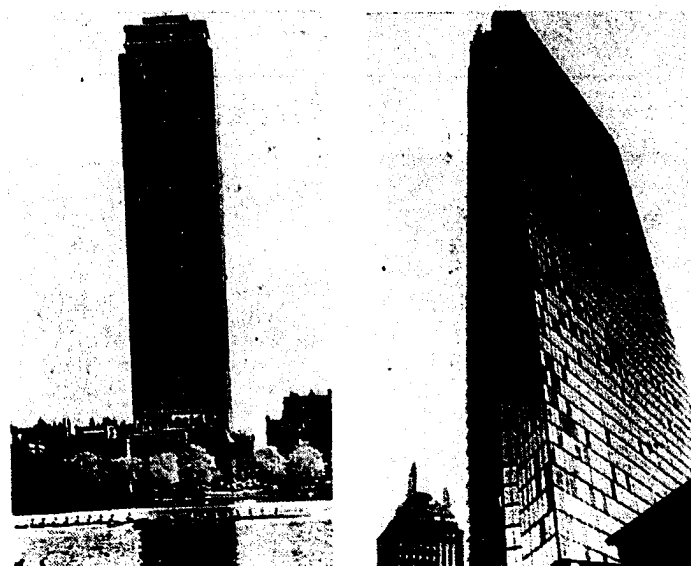




PRUDENTIAL AND HANCOCK BUILDINGS—A sense of proximity

The good and bad of high rise

The campaign against tall buildings is turning into a world-wide crusade.

In Britain, after one low-income tower collapsed, the government put a virtual ban on high-rise apartments throughout the country.

In France, a national controversy erupted over a proposal for high rise at La Defense, on the outskirts of the city, because the towers would have been visible above the Arc de Triomphe as you looked up the Champs Elysees. The battle went all the way to the President of France — who made a lot of enemies when he ruled in favor of the high rises.

In San Francisco, people got so concerned about what they call "Manhattanization" of their city that they put the issue to a referendum. High rises won there, too, but maybe not for long.

Closer to home, the Democratic City Committee in Cambridge recently passed a resolution recommending a moratorium on all high-rise construction in the city.

Most of us can remember when skyscrapers ranked with Mt. Rushmore and the Grand Canyon among the glories of the nation.

A trip to the top of the Empire State or RCA Building was the climax of any child's visit to the big city.

It used to be a cliché to describe the Manhattan skyline as "the greatest work of art of this century," or to compare the lofty office towers to the spires of Gothic cathedrals.

When he saw New York for the first time, the great French architect Le Corbusier commented that the only thing wrong with the city was that the skyscrapers weren't tall enough. Le Corbusier's own city planning schemes always featured skyscrapers of staggering proportions, and he went so far as to propose demolishing the center of Paris to accommodate these architectural mastodons.

When did it all change? Why did we fall out of love with tall buildings?

Surely one cause is a general retreat from the admiration for bigness as a goal in itself, and an under-

standing that the symbolic power of a tall building is no compensation for the lack of more human qualities.

The change goes back to Jane Jacobs' epochal book "Death and Life of great American Cities," published in 1961. Jacobs insisted that the life of healthy cities is in the streets and that the goal of city planning should be to generate the greatest possible variety of active street life. She proposed high-density but low-rise housing that would keep people close to the ground, with the buildings covering most of the land and leaving little open space other than the streets — the kind of approach we associate with the North End, as opposed to the taller buildings and useless open space of, say, Columbia Point.

Jacobs' book is 13 years old, yet so slow is the pace of change in city design that this summer New York's Museum of Modern Art is exhibiting as the latest breakthrough a series of prototype high-density low-rise housing designs done for the New York State Urban Development Corporation. Like everyone else, the UDC (the brainchild of Ed Logue, former head of the BRA) seems to have reached the conclusion that high-rise apartments for low-income families are unsafe and unlivable. You can't open your apartment-door onto an anonymous corridor on the 20th floor and tell your eight-year-old to go out and play; it's that simple.

Before the anti-high-rise tide turns into a fad, though, it's worth noting that the right kind of big buildings have some unique virtues, too. Grouped and sited according to an intelligent plan, they can not only live in peace with the rest of the city but can help give it a clearer, stronger shape and order.

For example: Before the Prudential and the new Hancock buildings were built in the no-man's land between the South End and Back Bay, a person standing on a street corner in the South End might have thought himself to be miles from the Back Bay — which in fact is just a

short walk away. Surveys showed that most people couldn't grasp the plan of the city and had no idea how close together these two neighborhoods — one a slum, the other a showpiece — really were.

Today, with big buildings sited where you can see them from either neighborhood, people on both sides sense their proximity and, in so doing, gain a better grasp of the way the city is organized. The city becomes more "imageable" in the jargon of planners. Perhaps not coincidentally, the South End's character is changing radically.

Proponents claim that if tall buildings in Boston could be kept out of small-scaled neighborhoods and concentrated, like the Prudential and Hancock, on or near the air rights over the Massachusetts Turnpike extension, this would create for Boston a "high spine" of skyscrapers that would clarify and give visual order to the city, while at the same time offering the big corporations who need the space a chance to remain, with their employees, in the city. And it wouldn't require tearing anything down, because the "spine" would be on reclaimed land over the turnpike.

Whether you buy the high spine concept or not — it's now the stated policy of the BRA and the Boston Society of Architects — it makes a point that's important, which is this: the real issue isn't high-rise versus low-rise; it's planning versus chaos.

If the high spine is ever realized, let's hope the new tall buildings won't repeat the ghastly mistake of the First National Bank building (to choose an arrogant but typical example), and leave the ground floor empty of anything except elevators. The ground is still the plane on which people contact each other, and every tall building must recognize this by offering to the public a ground floor of shops, gardens, cafes and restaurants, not a vacuous marble echo chamber.